The Glory Box (from Body Blows – Six Performances)

By Tim Miller

TIM: **(Pg 210)** *(to audience)* My partner Alistair is from Australia. **(Pg 216-217)** [He]and I were moving my mom's hope chest recently into the house where we live in Venice Beach. *(straining against the weight of the chest, to Alistair)* Damn, this thing weighs a ton! Did your mom have a hope chest?

ALISTAIR: Hmmm. No, she didn't have a hope chest, but she did have a glory box. I think that's the same thing.

TIM: A what?!? You've got to be kidding, right? You really call them GLORY BOXES?

ALISTAIR: Well, of course. What's so strange about that?

TIM: *(to audience)* Now that's more like it! Glory box! This changes everything. A glory box transforms a bland Southern California maiden into a resplendent Australian Joan of Arc astride her glory box! I've decided that I need a glory box right now in my life -- because Alistair and I are going through a hard time trying to stay together in a country that doesn't want us -- and I'm going to gather the things I need and put them into my glory box and make our future happen!

INTRODUCTION

The year was 1999 and the issue of gay marriage was just surfacing in the United States. Some states began to recognize and re-define marriage . . . others were completely opposed to the idea. The U.S. Government remained silent on the issue.

Now imagine if your partner was from another country. The struggles of accepting yourself and being accepted by society as a gay man in a committed relationship is compounded by an immigration system that doesn't recognize marriage rights of gay couples.

Glory Box by Tim Miller

TIM: **(Pg 210-211)** *(to audience)* I'm going to keep in it all kinds of good things my culture gave me as a young gay boy to prepare me for my queer life ahead -- the gay-positive role models, the encouragement of gay relationships, the after-school programs . . . HMMM.

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Well, since I actually didn't get any of those positive things, instead I'll put in the glory box the things I did get. I'm going to put in that glory box the hundreds of times I was called a sissy or faggot as a kid. I'm going to put in that glory box the thousands of signals I received from my culture that told me my relationships with other men aren't worth s*** and would never be acknowledged. *(fades into a memory of when he was 5-years-old)*

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TIM: When I was a kid, I was endlessly fascinated with this hope chest. Even the words themselves were a mystery. HOPE CHEST. I took these words literally. I was sure that they referred to an actual part of the body. If I looked in an anatomical reference book, I would see that HOPE CHEST was behind the sternum and to the left of the heart. We all know it's there. I imagined that this was the place inside us, a place where we could put the things we hoped for. I floated this notion out to my mom one afternoon. *(to Mom)* Mom?

MOM: **(Pg 213)** Yes, dear.

TIM: Is a hope chest a place inside me? A place where I put things I hope for? *(to audience)* My mom was preoccupied with her ironing and didn't want to entertain the queries of her young queer son, but she did her best.

MOM: Why, no, dear. A hope chest is something that was given to me when I was a girl. It was a special chest for me to put the things that I would need when I was married.

TIM: This was not the answer I had hoped for. This seemed to say that the hope chest was for practical things, like dishes and linens. "What kind of things?"

MOM: Oh, you know, practical things, like dishes and linens.

TIM: *(to audience)* This was sounding worse by the minute. I gave her one last chance. *(to Mom)* Didn't you ever put things you hoped for in there?

MOM: Hmm. Well . . . yes . . . I always hoped that I would have a good little boy like you, and here you are. Maybe the little girl that you will one day marry already has a hope chest and she's putting things in it to prepare for your marriage! Isn't that a lovely thought?

TIM: Eeew. I hate girls! I'll never get married.

MOM: You do not hate girls and you will too get married. Now, darling, mother's busy. Why

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don't you go and have a graham cracker?

****** *(flash to the present day at a customs-immigration checkpoint)* ******

TIM: **(Pg 217-221)** Now I'm in the future waiting outside of Immigration and Passport Control at Los Angeles International Airport. I'm waiting for Alistair to get through U.S. Customs. “What if they don't let Alistair into the country?" I'm being mugged by this thought. "What if they don't let Alistair into the country?" How can this man trust me so? How can he be so crazy to link his life with mine? Doesn't he know what damaged goods I am? Someone should tell him! Doesn't he know how scarred I am by what happened to me when I was nine years old?

****** *flash back* ******

TIM: It was a day of judgmental Twinkies being smashed in my face. I was walking down Russell Street with my friend Scott. We walked by a house that was widely regarded as the most tasteful in our neighborhood, much respected for its impressive series of ceramic elves decorating the winding walkway to the front door!

SCOTT: When I grow up, I'm going to marry that cute girl in our class Gail Gardener and we're gonna live in that house with the ceramic elves.

TIM: *(to audience)* Scott looked at me as if he thought he deserved a ninety-nine and a happy face on a spelling test. This was a new subject and I sensed that it meant trouble. I bought some time and walked silently along, my *Lost in Space* lunch box clanking against my leg. Next to my thermos was a special treat: a Twinkie in its crisp, confident plastic wrapper. I knew I was making a mistake before I even opened my mouth. *(to Scott)* But, Scott, when I grow up, I want to marry you and live in the house with the ceramic elves!

SCOTT: What! Boys can't get married to each other. Everybody knows that.

TIM: Why not?

SCOTT: They just can't.

TIM: *(to audience)* Scott pushed me hard with both hands, knocking me into the deep dusty ivy of my Congregationalist minister's front yard. Scott jumped on me, looking around to see if anyone had heard me ask him to marry him.

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SCOTT: Take it back! Say you don't want to marry me and live in the house with the elves!

TIM: I won't take it back!

SCOTT: Take it back, or I'll give you an Indian burn.

TIM: *(to audience)* He pinched my side hard and then grabbed my wrist with both hands and twisted in opposite directions. I screamed.

SCOTT: Do you take it back?

TIM: I won't take it back! *(to audience)* My lunch box had fallen open near my head, revealing the Twinkie in all its cellophane splendor. Scott got a horrible idea and grabbed the Twinkie in his little fist.

SCOTT: Take it back or I'm going to jam this Twinkie in your throat and kill you!

TIM: I won't take it back! *(to audience)* The strength of my high-pitched voice surprised me. *(to Scott)* When I grow up, I'm going to marry you and live in the house with the ceramic elves! *(to audience)* Scott shoved the Twinkie into my mouth and held his small dirty palm over my lips. I exploded with cellophane and Twinkie goo. Now, I knew I'd reached my Twinkie limit and I would have to take it back. Fortunately, my oldest brother had just taught me the week before a special trick. Whenever anyone is tormenting you and wanting you to be untrue to yourself and take something back, all you have to do is cross your fingers and put them behind your back. This erases it. *(crosses fingers behind back; to Scott)* Alright! I take it back. *(to audience)* Scott got off of me. He looked so strange. He kicked me, grabbed his math book and *Bonanza* lunch box, and stormed off to school and the rest of his life filled with petty disappointments and three wives who would fear him. (Don't ask me how, I just know!)

I lay there on my back, pinned to the earth. Surrounded by primordial ivy dust and Twinkie. *(holds crossed fingers up to the sky)* The crossing of those fingers negated my "I take it back," my one triumph over his small tyranny. I held them up to the hot California sun, and as I repeated the words they gathered steam inside me. I will never take it back. I will never take it back.

***** *(flash forward to Customs and Immigration)* *****

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TIM: **(Pg 233)** *(steps into scene and speaks to Allistair)* I promise you, it'll be okay. Why ***wouldn't*** they let you in? We're not doing anything wrong. We have the visa. We have the affidavit of support. I got a feeling this is gonna be fine. Trust me. *(puts hand gently against Allistair's cheek, then notices, as if for the first time, his hand)*

******* *flash back to a memory*******

TIM: *(to audience)* My hands. . . my hands . . . My hands have been slapped a lot in my life. My hand got slapped when I reached into the cookie jar for just one more. My hand got slapped when my first boyfriend was queer-bashed when I was eighteen. They yelled at him "Die Faggot Die" as they stabbed him nine times in the neck with an ice pick outside of a gay bar in Garden Grove, California. My hand got slapped when certain right-wing congressmen said that no lesbian or gay artists should be able to raise their voices in America.

******* a*nother flash of memory – Bozeman, Montana 1997* *******

TIM: **(Pg 234)** We're here in Bozeman, Montana. It's 1997 Lesbian and Gay Pride Weekend. BIG SKY PRIDE! I am here to perform for Montana Pride. **(Pg 235-236)** Two men in a pickup with a gun rack in the back window pull up and stop next to me. I know what's coming. I don't have to call the psychic friends network. What's coming is so predictable. What's coming are "F's."

MEN: Faggot. Fruit. Fairy. Freak.

TIM: They're predictable, but they're scary too, like an angry dog straining at its leash. I know that those F's were usually followed by something more concrete -- a rock, a bottle, maybe even a piece of concrete. Sure enough, a half-empty family-size bottle of Colt 45 leaves the passenger-side window. It made a graceful arc and hit me direct on my right hand. Hot blood dripping down my fingers. The bottle bounced and shattered at my feet. It's not too bad, five or six stitches tops, I just hope the guns stay in the gun rack.

I would like to say that at this moment I became homo superhero. I would tear off my clothes and instead of my vulnerable naked flesh, there would be an ugly superhero unitard costume. I would jump on the cab of their truck, kick the windshield in, and drag

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these two a**holes across the broken glass. But I didn't do any of those things. I'm not strong enough, or dumb enough to do that. I just bowed my head and walked quicker, a deer frozen in the oncoming headlights. Well, the light changed and the men in the truck lost interest in me. They threw one or two more F's and then went on their way. It's not enough that our country has tried to destroy [us], these men in the truck still want to stick our hands in the frying pan, hold our hands to the flame as I cross a beautiful street in Montana made ugly by these men's hate.

****** *return to Customs and Immigration* ******

TIM: **(Pg 238-241)** Alistair is next in line at Customs. He makes a shy smile and winks as he finally approaches the immigration officer and hands her his passport. She runs it through the scanner without even looking at him, and then looks through its pages.

OFFICER: Business or pleasure, Mr. McCartney?

ALISTAIR: I'm a student *(shifting from one foot to the other)* I'm here for study -- to do an MFA in creative writing at Antioch University in Los Angeles.

TIM: The immigration officer suddenly looks down at her computer screen. It's not a big look, but it's enough for me to know something bad is about to happen. She gestures to the armed immigration officer standing nearby, then looks directly at Alistair and says . . .

OFFICER: There's an irregularity in your request for a student visa. We have reason to believe that you have developed significant ties to an American citizen and that you will be a high risk for not leaving the U.S. at the end of your studies. You are being denied entry and will be returned to Australia on the next plane. Please pick up your belongings and go with this officer.

TIM: I can't breathe. I'm suddenly in a country that has no air for us. I tell myself I have to do whatever it takes to get one more breath. *(gasping, he approaches the officer)* Is there a problem here? Mr. McCartney is my . . . friend. I'm also his sponsor for his student visa.

COP: Please step back. Now, sir.

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TIM: *(to cop)* You don't understand, we're together. *(to audience)* Big Cop is getting angry.

COP: *(shouts)* Look, buddy, back off now or you're going to find yourself in big trouble.

TIM: I feel every moment I have been pushed around by cops, every time I have had a bottle thrown at me, every time I had felt my love for another man be s***-on by my country. This isn't happening.

Little Cop has a choke hold on Alistair and is dragging him away, pulling him toward a strange door covered in smoked glass. Big Cop has got me. *(to cops)* You a**holes, he's my lover, my partner, my husband. You can't do this. I'm an American citizen. I have rights! You can't do this. *(to audience)* The doors shut on Alistair. They are dragging me away. The woman officer at her computer terminal regards this scene with annoyance. She glares at the U.S. citizens who have already made it through the lines, their mouths agape with the shame that comes when you watch injustice and do nothing. But all she says . . .

OFFICER: Next.

******* *(returns to the hope chest/glory box)* *******

TIM: I have one more thing in that hope chest. In that glory box. There's a compass inside. I hope that this compass will help me and Alistair avoid a future like that at some airport in America. ut I have an even better compass inside me too. Right here in my hope chest. It's right where I knew it was. I was right when I was five. There is this place inside us. It's right here, behind my sternum and to the left of my heart. It's the compass that led me to love another man -- a man from another country. It led me around the world to find him.

I will use my compass to find a place where when two men kiss, the cop on the beat or the airplane captain will nod, smile, see us as the tin-canned newlyweds we are. I want to use this compass to find my way to a place where our hands won't be pulled apart. I want to use this compass to find my way to a place where two men or two women can come together and pledge their lives, their hopes, their fears, their failures, their myths, their memories and their bodies the sight of the gods, the goddesses, the state, the little

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children, and even my mom. I don't want to have to leave my country to find this place. I don't want to be ***forced*** to leave my pathetic, frustrating, hate-filled, when-will-we-grow-up and ever beloved country. I may even want to use this compass to find that house with the ceramic elves. If I want to. I'm going to use this compass to find my way home. To find my way . . . to him.

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AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2020 National Qualifier
NCFL Qualifier
IL State Finalist

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